

Project: Clara Vane

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 21 & 22

CHAPTER 21: THE SHAMAN

The courtroom was a sterile box of American jurisprudence. Oak panels. Great Seal. Fluorescent lights that hummed in the key of B-flat.

It was a room designed to strip the mystery out of the world and replace it with Statute.

Dr. Kalu did not fit in this box.

She sat on the witness stand, a woman carved from obsidian. Her hair was wrapped in a vibrant saffron cloth that seemed to vibrate against the drab beige of the walls. Around her neck, she wore a necklace of rough, dark stones.

When she moved, they clicked.

Clack-clack.

It sounded like dice rolling. Or teeth chattering.

Sarah Jones stood at the podium.

"Dr. Kalu," Sarah said. "Please state your occupation."

"I am a Cultural Anthropologist," Kalu said. Her voice was low, resonant. It carried to the back of the room without a microphone. "I specialize in the intersection of indigenous belief systems and psychopathology."

"You study crazy people?" The Prosecutor, Miller, muttered under his breath.

"Objection," Sarah snapped.

"Sustained," the Judge said. "Mr. Miller, keep your commentary to yourself."

Sarah continued. "Dr. Kalu, you have reviewed the case file of Clara Vane. You have read the transcripts of her 'episodes'. In your expert opinion... what was happening to her?"

Kalu looked at the jury. She didn't blink.

"In your culture," she said, "you have a book called the DSM-5. It is a catalogue of broken things. You look at a girl who speaks in tongues, who convulses, who knows the secrets of strangers... and you say 'Schizophrenia'. You say 'Epilepsy'. You say 'Chemical Imbalance'."

She leaned forward. *Clack-clack.*

"You name the monster, and you think that kills it."

"And in other cultures?" Sarah asked.

"I lived with the Yoruba in Nigeria. I lived with the Hmong in Laos. In those places, the monster has a different name. We call it *Egun*. We call it *Dab*."

"And how do they treat it?"

"They do not drug it," Kalu said. "They do not lock it in a white room and hope it goes away. They invite it in."

"Invite it?"

"They acknowledge that the person is a vessel. A door has been opened. The Shaman's job is not to close the door with chemicals. It is to stand in the doorway and negotiate with what is coming through."

Sarah walked to the defense table. She picked up the photo of Clara Vane—the one where she was tied to the bed, screaming.

"Dr. Vogel, the neurologist, testified that Clara was suffering from a 'fire in the brain'. A random electrical storm."

"Dr. Vogel looks at the map and thinks he sees the territory," Kalu said dismissively. "He sees the lightning. He does not see the hand that throws it."

"So, you believe Clara was possessed?"

"I believe," Kalu said, "that Clara Vane experienced a reality that your science is too young to understand. To her, the possession was real. The demons were real. And because she believed it... her body obeyed the laws of that reality. Not the laws of Dr. Vogel."

Miller stood up for cross-examination. He buttoned his jacket. He looked like a man about to discipline a child.

"Dr. Kalu," he said, walking to the stand. "Let's talk about 'reality'. Do you believe in germs?"

"I do."

"Do you believe in gravity?"

"I do."

"Good. Because those are scientifically proven facts. Now... do you have any *proof*—any empirical, peer-reviewed proof—that demons exist?"

Kalu smiled. It wasn't a nice smile.

"Mr. Miller," she said. "Do you love your wife?"

Miller blinked. "Excuse me?"

"Do you love her?"

"Yes. Of course."

"Prove it," Kalu said. "Show me the molecule of love. Put it under a microscope. Measure it."

"That's abstract," Miller sputtered. "That's an emotion."

"It is a force," Kalu said. "It drives you. It changes your behavior. It makes you buy flowers. It makes you kill. It is invisible, but it is real. The Spirit World is the same. We cannot put it in a test tube. But we can see its footprints."

"We are talking about a dead girl!" Miller shouted. "Not flowers! This 'Spirit World' of yours killed her!"

"No," Kalu said. Her voice dropped to a whisper. "Your arrogance killed her. You told a girl who was drowning in the ocean that the water wasn't real. You threw her a textbook instead of a rope."

Miller slammed his hand on the railing.

"Your Honor! The witness is hostile!"

"The witness is truthful," Kalu said.

She looked at Juror 11—the Nurse.

"You know," Kalu said to the nurse. "You have seen them. In the ICU. At 3:00 AM. The ones who scream when there is no pain. The ones who look at the corner of the room and see the dark man standing there."

Juror 11 shivered. She nodded.

"Stop!" Miller yelled. "Strike that from the record!"

"The jury will disregard the witness's comment to the juror," the Judge said.

But it was too late.

The bridge had been built.

Kalu had turned the courtroom from a box of law into a place of shadows.

And in the shadows, the DSM-5 didn't matter.

Only the dark man in the corner mattered.

And he was watching.

CHAPTER 22: THE SANCTION

The Chancery of the Archdiocese was designed to intimidate.

It was a fortress of limestone and stained glass, a palace for the Princes of the Church.

Father Thomas stood in the waiting room. He felt small. He felt dirty.

His shoes were scuffed with mud from the Vane farm. His cassock smelled of sweat and fear.

Around him, the walls were lined with portraits of Bishops past. Severe men with oil-painted eyes that seemed to follow him.

Judgment, they whispered. *You are out of your depth, little priest.*

The heavy oak doors opened.

A secretary, a young man with perfect hair and a suit that cost more than Thomas's car, stepped out.

"The Bishop will see you now."

Thomas walked in.

Bishop O'Malley's office was vast. A Persian rug covered the floor. A desk the size of an altar dominated the room.

O'Malley was eating lunch. A Cobb salad on fine china.

"Thomas," he said, dabbing his mouth with a linen napkin. "Sit."

Thomas sat. The leather chair was soft, swallowing him.

"I read your report," O'Malley said. He tapped a folder on his desk. "It's... distressing."

"It's a crisis, Your Excellency. Clara Vane is deteriorating."

"She is sick, Thomas. Dr. Vogel says it is epilepsy."

"Dr. Vogel is wrong. I was there last night. She spoke Aramaic. She knew about my mother. She knew about... the incident in the seminary."

O'Malley stopped chewing. His eyes narrowed.

"What incident?"

"The fire," Thomas whispered. "She knew who started it."

O'Malley put his fork down. The clatter was loud in the silence.

"That information is sealed."

"Not to her," Thomas said. "Not to the Thing inside her."

"Thing?" O'Malley sighed. "Thomas, we live in the twentieth century. We do not chase ghosts. If we authorize an exorcism, and it goes wrong... the liability is catastrophic. The Church cannot afford a scandal."

"She is a child of God!" Thomas said, his voice rising. "She is being eaten alive! And we are worried about lawsuits?"

"We are worried about the survival of the Institution," O'Malley snapped. "Without the Institution, there are no sacraments. No salvation."

Thomas stood up. He walked to the window.

"She asked me to kill her," he said softly. "Last night. She begged me to end it. She said the fire in her head was too hot."

He turned to the Bishop.

"If we do nothing, she dies. And her soul... I don't know what happens to her soul."

O'Malley looked at Thomas. He looked at the desperation in the young priest's face.

He opened a drawer in his desk.

He pulled out a document.

It was heavy parchment. Wax seal.

"This is the *Rituale Romanum*," O'Malley said. "Authorization for a Major Exorcism."

Thomas reached for it.

O'Malley pulled it back.

"There are conditions."

"Anything."

"Condition one: No press. No media. This never happened."

"Agreed."

"Condition two: A doctor must be present. To certify death, if it comes."

"Agreed."

"Condition three," O'Malley said. His voice was cold. "If you fail... if she dies... the Church will disavow you. We will say you acted alone. We will say you were a rogue priest who lost his mind."

Thomas froze.

"You would hang me out to dry?"

"To save the Body? Yes. Without hesitation."

O'Malley held out the paper.

"Take it. But know this, Thomas. You are walking into that room alone. God may be with you, but the Church will not be."

Thomas looked at the document.

It looked like a death warrant.

He took it.

"Thank you, Your Excellency."

"Don't thank me," O'Malley said, picking up his fork. "Just don't miss."

Thomas walked out of the office.

He walked down the long, marble hallway.

He felt the weight of the paper in his pocket.

It was lighter than a soul.

But it was heavy enough to drown him.

He pressed the elevator button.

Going Down.

He looked at his reflection in the brass doors.

He looked like a man who had just sold everything he owned for a ticket to a war he couldn't win.

But as the doors opened, he saw a shadow in the empty elevator car.

A tall, thin shadow.

It tipped its hat.

Thomas stepped in.

"Let's finish this," he whispered.

And the doors closed on the light.